Recovering, I realised that I'd signed into the hotel with a credit card and that several people had seen me. I had to get out of there fast and assess the situation properly and understand what was going on. You mustn't forget how paranoid I was in general at that point, and how conspiratorial. I couldn't believe A—— and W—— were actually doing this, and couldn't for the life of me work out how it could come about. So I got out of the hotel and went on a train to a friend's house in the north of Sweden. It didn't seem possible to go to the police because I just couldn't trust that there wasn't some general effort afoot to capture me. It seemed so surreal and so unexpected. And it was impossible to say, at that point, whether this had been some kind of set-up, or whether the women were jealous, because, frankly, after pausing for thought and discussing it with friends, I saw that both things were possible, though I understand it had to be one or the other.

I did not rape those women and cannot imagine anything that happened between us that would make them think so, except malice after the fact, a joint plan to entrap me, or a terrible misunderstanding that was stoked up between them. I may be a chauvinist pig of some sort but I am no rapist, and only a distorted version of sexual politics could attempt to turn me into one. They each had sex with me willingly and were happy to hang out with me afterwards. That is all.

But, in modern Sweden, that is not all. In some ways, it might be fair to see Sweden as a place that is isolated from the rest of Europe. It has traditionally had an inclination towards neutrality and is something of an enclosed world, with a population of less than ten million dominated by a few powerful institutions in Stockholm. Sweden has a reputation for political stability and consensus, partly as a result of the Social Democratic Party's dominance of national politics for most of the twentieth century. But things have been changing, and not clearly for the better. In 2001, Sweden, under the SDP, sent troops to Afghanistan, which was the first deployment of troops in an overseas military operation for almost two hundred years. This reflects a turn away from their previous policy of neutrality in foreign relations, and a growing orientation towards the United States. In Cable 09-141, which we later released as part of Cablegate, the American ambassador in Stockholm made clear the extent of American pressure – and Swedish compliance – over the issue of computer file-sharing and government monitoring of computer traffic. Worse still, a Human Rights Watch report published in 2006 detailed Swedish complicity and co-operation in the